

outreach programme will turn the tide in their favour. Moreover, with as many as 150 madrasas and educational institutions, Azamgarh plays a significant role in shaping the socio-political mood of Muslims there. Buoyed by his success at Aligarh Muslim University, Rahul is said to be planning a similar visit to Azamgarh's

**SINGH IN AZAMGARH WITH
LOCAL MUSLIM LEADERS**

Uttar Pradesh echoes Digvijay's own strategic thinking. As chief minister he had opposed an alliance with the BSP in Madhya Pradesh in 1998 by saying, "The Congress loses whenever it goes for a piggyback ride. Even in Uttar Pradesh if we cannot fight all the seats we should contest a limited number on our own." This is a philosophy that is a cornerstone of Rahul's politics. "Can't two people think

mood of the leadership, and he would never speak without first clearing his lines with the famed high command. "No Congressman said that Afzal Guru should not be hanged. But we were unnecessarily blamed for being soft on terror. Someone had to react, so I did. But the two issues (Azamgarh and Afzal Guru are not related," he said. Later, when the party was negotiating seats with the Samajwadi Party for the 2009 polls, Digvijay's hard negotiations broke off the talks. By then, it was clear that his actions had Rahul's go-ahead.



Digvijay often says that politics is the art of the possible. He should know. Almost six years ago when the defeated Raja of Raghogarh moved to Delhi, he was not so self-assured and often rushed off to Madhya Pradesh playing state politics even though he had said he would not fight an election for 10 years. It was to deflect him from Madhya Pradesh that he was given charge of Uttar Pradesh, a job that no one envied. This coincided with Rahul's interest in the state and the smooth Singh soon turned the challenge into an opportunity.

Rahul had an instant rapport with the tech-savvy Thakur who talked

"This is not minority appeasement. Had it been so, I would not have been shown black flags by the Ulema council."

National Shibli College.

However, Digvijay denies that he is playing Chanakya to Rahul's Chandragupta. "Rahul has a mind of his own. He decides and I follow," the 62-year-old general secretary told INDIA TODAY. "I am not Rahul's mouthpiece; he does not need one. As far as Uttar Pradesh is concerned, we discuss things and I implement whatever is decided." Ever since Digvijay was given charge of the state in 2007, the two have worked in tandem with the older politician playing both mentor and implementor. Interestingly, Rahul's theory of going it alone in

alike? I'm grateful that my thinking matches his (Rahul)," says Digvijay. In the slippery slope of Congress politics, he is not being humble. He is being pragmatic.

This is not the first time that Digvijay Raja, as he is popularly known, has set the party's agenda. Earlier, when the BJP demanded the Congress's view on hanging Afzal Guru, the party spokesmen hemmed and hawed. Digvijay seized the initiative and said that "the Congress has no problem if Afzal Guru is hanged". Later, this became the official party line.

He is sharp enough to gauge the

development politics at international universities and at the grassroots. As chief minister, he included civil society and intellectuals in governance, a model that finds favour with his young boss. Today, firmly ensconced in Delhi's durbar, he doesn't want to return to Madhya Pradesh. "If Soniaji wants me to contest the 2014 elections, I will. But I will not go back to the state right now," he says. He once said that there is "something called fate and something called opportunity". The state leader-turned-national player knows how to make the most of both. **with Subhash Mishra**